

Light for the Whole World

Acts 13:46-49

Then Paul and Barnabas answered them boldly: "We had to speak the word of God to you first. Since you reject it and do not consider yourselves worthy of eternal life, we now turn to the Gentiles. For this is what the Lord has commanded us: "I have made you a light for the Gentiles, that you may bring salvation to the ends of the earth." When the Gentiles heard this, they were glad and honored the word of the Lord; and all who were appointed for eternal life believed. The word of the Lord spread through the whole region.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

During this time of year, the amount of daylight is pretty short. Imagine living in Fairbanks, Alaska where the sun shines for only 3 ½ hours on the shortest day of the year! Light is important for a lot of different reasons.

Now imagine you're in a dark room with a flashlight. Imagine if the flashlight was under a pillow, so only a little light got out. Not very helpful, right? But then you move the pillow away so the flashlight shines brightly, lighting up everything around.

Paul and Barnabas remind us that God's message of love and forgiveness is like that light. At first, the good news about Jesus came to the Jewish people, God's chosen people. But not everyone believed it. So, Paul and Barnabas shared the message with the Gentiles, people from other nations who didn't know God's promises yet. Paul reminded everyone that God's plan was always for Jesus to be "a light for the Gentiles" too, bringing salvation to the whole world.

When the Gentiles heard this, they were overjoyed! Imagine hearing for the first time that God's love isn't just for a small group of people, but for everyone. Jesus came to save people from all nations, backgrounds, and ages. Through him, God opened the door for everyone to receive eternal life—Jews and Gentiles alike.

The same is true for us today. Jesus' life, death, and resurrection made it possible for everyone, including us, to be forgiven and have a relationship with God. Just as Paul and Barnabas were sent to share God's message of forgiveness and love, God invites us to share it, too. We can share the good news with our friends, our neighbors, or even someone who's never heard it before. God wants his message to be like a bright light reaching everyone, all the way to "the ends of the earth." He wants it to shine for everyone!

How can we help that light reach others? Maybe it's telling a friend about Jesus, praying for someone, or even helping others see God's love through our kindness. This light of Jesus is too great and bright to keep to ourselves!

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- How do you feel when you hear that Jesus loves everyone, including you?
- Who could you tell about Jesus this week, like a friend or family member?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Paul and Barnabas shared the message of Jesus even with people who hadn't heard it before. Why is it important to tell others about Jesus?
- TRUE or FALSE. God's love is for those who believe in him.

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Paul calls Jesus "a light for the Gentiles." How does that challenge you to rethink how you interact with people who don't yet know Jesus?
- There's a lot of darkness out there. How might your actions and words be like a "light" to someone going through a dark time?

Closing Prayer:

Dear Jesus, let the good news of what you have done for all people be a light dawning on the whole world! Help us hold onto this good news and spread it wherever we go. Amen.